endless encounters at Margot's bedsit. Realising her husband had strayed, Edith penned a desperate letter to Ulbricht complaining that Erich never came home before one o'clock in the morning. 'Something burns like a fire in him,' she lamented. 'He can't get away from the girl … I found out that she asked him three times to divorce me.' The solution, she suggested in a postscript, was to 'kick Margot Feist out of the FDJ and send her back to Sachsen-Anhalt'.2 Although Ulbricht – a strict moralist in such matters – was appalled by the affair, the lovers found a powerful supporter in Wilhelm Pieck, who tried to defuse the issue. Honecker quietly moved out of Puderstraße, but Baumann resisted being convinced, or coerced, into divorce. She quit the FDJ and took a position in the secretariat of the SED Politburo.3 Outwardly, she remained stoic and defiant, but her bitterness was immense and before long, she upped sticks to Pankow where she lived with Erica and her elderly father. In the months that followed, Erich's love affair with Margot reached its climax. As her star rose, she undertook several training trips to Moscow, and with her lover's help, climbed the ranks of the FDJ, ending up in Baumann's old job.

Paradoxically, Honecker had every reason – and more so as it turned out – for optimism as 1950 dawned. His messy private life failed to disrupt his career or efforts to transform the FDJ into a vehicle for Soviet indoctrination.

With the calming presence of Edith gone, he adopted an authoritarian working style to control the FDJ bureaucratic apparatus across departments dealing with working-class youth, rural youth, West German work, culture and education, students, sport and young pioneers. According to Heinz Lippmann, a dominant style of leadership evolved which saw Honecker speak more often and more loudly. Whenever there was criticism, there was a ready defence – he brooked no dissent, and 'abandoned efforts at collective leadership and returned to the old style of decreeing. There were hardly any fundamental discussions or criticism.'4

In terms of productivity, Honecker helped draft the first youth laws, including measures to promote sport, hiking and recreation. Furthermore, he devised a 'sports badge' for athletic accomplishments and pushed for the